

ABSTRACT

This study aims to explore the content and significance of reading and writing experiences especially in 5-year-old children. The central research question is “ How do 5-year-old children in the ‘Tree’ class experience reading and writing, and how do these experiences impact their literacy development? “ The participants were 13 children aged 5 from the J kindergarten’s ‘Tree’ class. The research was conducted from March 27, 2023, to August 31, 2023, involving participatory observations centered around morning class times, two to three times a week. The results of the study are as follows.

Firstly, children experienced reading and writing through various types of representational media. In this context, text existed as one of the optional representational media for reading and writing. Children actively utilized pictures and symbols not just as supporting tools because they couldn’t read or write text, but as tools for self-expression and means of acquiring information. Furthermore, when they chose text as their representational media, they utilized surrounding resources to facilitate their reading and writing experiences.

Secondly, children experienced reading and writing comfortably in a natural environment, utilizing the characteristics of written information. They showed a spontaneous desire to learn text and use it in their own way, blending seamlessly into their learning environment. They repeatedly observed and compared the shapes of written characters to gain knowledge about them and information for play, indicating a voluntary motivation to learn and use text in a way that suited their needs.

Thirdly, the children’s reading and writing were not confined to specific activities or times but were intertwined with play and daily life. Play and everyday activities provided the foundational framework for reading and writing, where children integrated these skills with their personal encounters, and expressed and shared their thoughts, thereby acquiring literacy skills as an integral part of their daily life.

The findings indicate that children experienced reading and writing in various contexts, understanding the functions and meanings of text and skillfully utilizing it for expression within social interactions. From the perspective of literacy that emphasizes expression and communication using texts, children were already engaged in meaningful reading and writing experiences. This study is intended to serve as a basis for reflecting on the significance of children’s reading and writing experiences in the field of early childhood literacy.